

There's a ringing to the air. Surely you can hear that. It's loud, oppressive, rattling through my head, I want to scream, to scream as loud as I can to drown out this damned ringing.

I don't hear myself, all I hear is the ring.

And then a thud. Two thuds. Three thuds. Drowned out by this infernal ring but ever present in the background.

I try to focus on this noise. It's comforting, in a way.

The ever present beating of my heart. It's comforting to know that even now, my body is still fighting to keep going, and as long as I still hear my heart, I'm still alive, and if I'm alive, then I can keep going.

Moving is a struggle. It hurts. The slightest twitch and my muscles feel like they're on fire, even the rise and fall of my chest as I draw breath hurts like a thousand knives digging into my ribs, as I try to ignore the parts of me I can't feel anymore. Focus on the pain, don't focus on the numbness, the emptiness of what might not be there anymore.

But I'm alive. My heart tells me that much, so I keep going, keep twisting, keep pushing despite the pain, and the more I do, the less it hurts, until after what feels like ages, I'm free.

Through all the ringing, and the pain, I've been in darkness.

I don't know if I can't open my eyes, but I don't know if I want to.

If I try to and fail, then I know that I can't.

If I try to succeed, then the first thing I'll look at is what's left of me.

I know I'll need to try at some point.

I am alive, and I can't spend the rest of my life never knowing if I'll ever open my eyes again.

I can't tell how long I've been here.

How long I've been buried, how long I've laid here in the ruin, listening to this ringing and the beating of my heart.

After what feels like eternity I finally try.

I am alive, I need to move, I need to try to see and with what feels like a monumental effort, I peek my eyelids open.

And all I can see is red.